defence indigenization) and an industrial policy (with a focus on critical and emerging technologies). It can also better leverage international partnerships to accelerate domestic development, drawing both from its own prior experiences in agriculture, education, health, telecommunications, and transportation, and by reflecting upon the historical experiences of other rising powers, including the United States, Russia, and especially Japan and China. Ultimately, India cannot afford to mistake self-reliance for isolationism.

The near neighbourhood also remains a priority, as described in Chapter 7: Neighbourhood First. India has five privileged partnerships in its immediate periphery—Bhutan, Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives—which deserve a priority in its international outlook, in addition to regional partners such as Myanmar, Afghanistan, Mauritius, and Seychelles, where India is less omnipresent. In its near neighbourhood, India confronts rising democratization, populism, concerns about sovereignty, and a growing Chinese presence. To address these complex dynamics, India must offer greater diplomatic priority and attention to these neighbours, including further investments by the strategic and scholarly community. It must also recast regional cooperation in a more constructive light; increase aid, lending, and humanitarian assistance; and improve connectivity to enhance trade, investment, energy flows, and people-to-people exchanges. These steps—which are encapsulated in a policy of ‘Neighbourhood First’—can help mitigate volatility in relations with neighbours.

India confronts a much greater challenge in China’s rise and assertiveness, as described in Chapter 8: Act East. Maintaining a balance of power has required India to place a greater emphasis on security, imagine a wider region, and increase the urgency of delivery in its Look East Policy. This has resulted in a new name and approach: the Act East Policy. The new geographical scope, in turn, has required conceiving of the Indo–Pacific, which envisions the Indian and Pacific oceans as a single strategic continuum. In practice, ‘Acting East’ in the Indo–Pacific requires India to take steps to secure the Indian Ocean, using its naval capabilities, strategic